

Mohammad Reza Taesiri

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RESEARCH HIGHLIGHTS

My research focuses on training and evaluating foundation models, with a specific emphasis on evaluating Vision-Language Models (VLMs) through rigorous, large-scale benchmarking. The benchmarks I have developed have been adopted by industry leaders including **OpenAI**, **Google DeepMind**, **ByteDance**, **Alibaba**, and **NVIDIA** to evaluate their flagship models such as **Gemini 3.0 Pro**, **o3**, and **Nemotron-VL2**.
Keywords: VLMs, VLAs, World Models, Post-training, Evals

CURRENT POSITION

EA Sports, Vancouver, BC, Canada
▪ Machine Learning Scientist May 2025 – Present

EDUCATION

University of Alberta, Edmonton, Alberta, Canada
▪ Ph.D. in Software Engineering and Intelligent Systems Sep 2021 – Sep 2024
Sharif University of Technology, Tehran, Iran
▪ M.Sc. in Computer Software Engineering Sep 2015 – Sep 2017
Amirkabir University of Technology, Tehran, Iran
▪ B.Sc. in Pure Mathematics Sep 2009 – Jun 2015

EXPERIENCE

Nguyen Lab, Auburn University
▪ Visiting Researcher Mar 2021 – Present
• Supervisor: Prof. Anh Totti Nguyen
• Focus: Robust and Explainable Machine Learning
ASGAARD Lab, University of Alberta
▪ Postdoctoral researcher Oct 2024 – May 2025
• Supervisor: Dr. Cor-Paul Bezemer
• Focus: Vision-language models for understanding the world and detecting anomalies
La Forge, Ubisoft Montreal
▪ Research and Development Intern Aug 2022 – Dec 2022
• Supervisor: Dr. Sarra Habchi
• Focus: Robustness of Foundation Models, Image and Video Retrieval
ASGAARD Lab, University of Alberta
▪ Graduate Research Assistant Sep 2021 – Sep 2024
• Supervisor: Prof. Cor-Paul Bezemer
• Focus: Foundation Models for Video Games

PUBLICATIONS

CONFERENCES

- [1] J Roberts, [Mohammad Reza Taesiri](#), A Sharma, A Gupta, S Roberts, I Croitoru, et al. – “ZeroBench: An Impossible Visual Benchmark for Contemporary Large Multimodal Models” in *The Forty-Third International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML 2026)*
- [2] A Vo, KN Nguyen, [Mohammad Reza Taesiri](#), VT Dang, AT Nguyen, and D Kim – “Vision Language Models are Biased” in *The Fourteenth International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR 2026)*
- [3] [Mohammad Reza Taesiri](#), A Ghildyal, S Zadtootaghaj, N Barman, and CP Bezemer – “VideoGameQA-Bench: Evaluating Vision-Language Models for Video Game Quality Assurance” in *The Thirty-Ninth Annual Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2025)*
- [4] [Mohammad Reza Taesiri](#), B Collins, L Bolton, VD Lai, F Dernoncourt, T Bui, and AT Nguyen – “Understanding Generative AI Capabilities in Everyday Image Editing Tasks” in *The IEEE/CVF Winter Conference on Applications of Computer Vision (WACV 2026)*

- [5] A Vo, Mohammad Reza Taesiri, D Kim, and AT Nguyen – “B-score: Detecting biases in large language models using response history” in *Forty-Second International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML 2025)*
- [6] Mohammad Reza Taesiri, and Cor-Paul Bezemer – “VideoGameBunny: Towards vision assistants for video games” in *Proceedings of the IEEE/CVF Winter Conference on Applications of Computer Vision 2025. (WACV 2025, Oral)*
- [7] Rahmanzadehgervi, Pooyan, Logan Bolton, Mohammad Reza Taesiri, and Anh Totti Nguyen – “Vision language models are blind” in *Proceedings of the Asian Conference on Computer Vision 2024. (ACCV 2024, Oral)*
- [8] Mohammad Reza Taesiri, Tianjun Feng, Anh Nguyen and Cor-Paul Bezemer – “GlitchBench: Can large multimodal models detect video game glitches?” in *Proceedings of the IEEE/CVF Conference on Computer Vision and Pattern Recognition 2024. (CVPR 2024)*
- [9] Mohammad Reza Taesiri, Giang Nguyen, Sarra Habchi, Cor-Paul Bezemer, and Anh Nguyen – “ImageNet-Hard: The Hardest Images Remaining from a Study of the Power of Zoom and Spatial Biases in Image Classification” in *Thirty-Seventh Annual Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2023)*
- [10] Mohammad Reza Taesiri*, Giang Nguyen*, and Anh Nguyen (* Denotes Equal Contribution) – “Visual correspondence-based explanations improve AI robustness and human-AI team accuracy.” in *Thirty-sixth Annual Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2022)*
- [11] Finlay Macklon, Mohammad Reza Taesiri, Markos Viggiano, Stefan Antoszko, Natalia Romanova, Dale Paas, and Cor-Paul Bezemer – “Automatically Detecting Visual Bugs in HTML5 <canvas> Games.” in *International Conference on Automated Software Engineering (ASE 2022)*
- [12] Mohammad Reza Taesiri, Finlay Macklon, and Cor-Paul Bezemer – “CLIP meets GamePhysics: Towards bug identification in gameplay videos using zero-shot transfer learning.” in *The Mining Software Repositories conference (MSR 2022)*

JOURNALS

- [13] Tin Nguyen, Logan Bolton, Mohammad Reza Taesiri, and Anh Totti Nguyen – “HoT: Highlighted Chain of Thought for Referencing Supporting Facts from Inputs” in *Transactions on Machine Learning Research (TMLR 2026)*
- [14] Giang Nguyen, Valerie Chen, Mohammad Reza Taesiri, and Anh Totti Nguyen – “PCNN: Probable-Class Nearest-Neighbor Explanations Improve Fine-Grained Image Classification Accuracy for AIs and Humans” in *Transactions on Machine Learning Research (TMLR)*
- [15] Mohammad Reza Taesiri, Finlay Macklon, Sarra Habchi, and Cor-Paul Bezemer – “Searching bug instances in gameplay video repositories” in *IEEE Transactions on Games (ToG 2024)*
- [16] Mohammad Reza Taesiri, Moslem Habibi, and MohammadAmin Fazli – “A Video Game Testing Method Utilizing Deep Learning” in *Journal on Computer Science and Engineering (JCSE 2021)*

WORKSHOPS

- [17] Giang Nguyen, Mohammad Reza Taesiri, Sunnie S. Y. Kim, and Anh Totti Nguyen – “Allowing humans to interactively guide machines where to look does not always improve a human-AI team’s classification accuracy.” in *The 3rd Explainable AI for Computer Vision (XAI4CV) Workshop (CVPR 2024)*

PREPRINTS

- [18] Mohammad Reza Taesiri, Finlay Macklon, Yihe Wang, Hengshuo Shen, and Cor-Paul Bezemer – “Large Language Models are Pretty Good Zero-Shot Video Game Bug Detectors.” in *arXiv Preprint*
- [19] MohammadAmin Fazli*, Ali Owfi*, and Mohammad Reza Taesiri* (* Denotes Equal Contribution) – “A Data-Driven Analysis on NFT Auctions: Assessment, Opportunities and Fraudulent Activities.” in *arXiv Preprint*

	▪ Alberta Graduate Excellence Scholarship (AGES) 2023 ▪ Upper Bound Talent Bursary 2023 ▪ NeurIPS Scholar Award 2022 ▪ Graduate Research Assistant, University of Alberta 2021 ▪ Ranked 10th, National entrance exam in Software Engineering, Iran 2015 ▪ Ranked 11th, National entrance exam in Algorithms and Theory of Computation, Iran 2015
INVITED TALKS & ACTIVITIES	Foundation Models for Video Game Quality Assurance, 2024 Honours Seminar, University of Alberta, Edmonton, Canada A Brief Tutorial on Large Language Models, 2023 ISAIC, University of Alberta, Edmonton, Canada Zoom Is What You Need: An empirical study of the power of zoom and spatial biases in image classification, 2023 Samsung SAIT AI Lab (SAIL), Montreal, Québec, Canada
PROJECTS & DATASETS	VideoGameQA-Bench ▪ A benchmark to evaluate vision language models for the task of video game quality assurance. May 2025 VLMsAreBiased ▪ A benchmark for evaluating bias in vision language models. May 2025 VLMsAreBlind ▪ A benchmark for evaluating vision-language models on basic visual perception primitives. May 2024 GlitchBench ▪ A benchmark to evaluate large multimodal models for the task of video game testing. Dec 2023 ImageNet-Hard ▪ Introduced a challenging dataset to rigorously assess the robustness of diverse vision models. Apr 2023 Claude Reads ArXiv ▪ Harnessing the power of the <i>Claude-v1.3-100k</i> to answer questions about academic papers. Apr 2023 Intelligent Image Captioner ▪ Empowering ChatGPT with the ability to see and interpret images, using Detic. Dec 2022 CLIP Meets GamePhysics, Hugging Face Spaces ▪ Developed a CLIP-based video retrieval system for video games. Mar 2022 The GamePhysics Dataset, Hugging Face Datasets ▪ A dataset of video game bugs Jan 2022
TEACHING EXPERIENCE	University of Alberta, Edmonton, Alberta, Canada ▪ Teaching Assistant Sep 2023 – May 2024 • Served as a teaching assistant for multiple courses. • ECE 447 - Data Analysis and Machine Learning for Engineers - Winter 2024 • ECE 342 - Probability for Electrical and Computer Engineers - Winter 2024 • ECE 325 - Object-Oriented Software Design - Fall 2023 • ECE 321 - Software Requirements Engineering - Fall 2023 Sharif University of Technology, Tehran, Iran ▪ Teaching Assistant - Head Jan 2016 – Jun 2016 • Led a team of teaching assistants in the Discrete-Event Simulation course. • Collaborated with the professor to develop lesson plans, assess students' performance
CERTIFICATES & ONLINE COURSES	▪ Deep Reinforcement Learning Nanodegree, Udacity 2020 ▪ Reinforcement Learning Specialization, Coursera, University of Alberta 2020 ▪ Computational Neuroscience, Coursera, University of Washington 2020 ▪ Deep Learning Specialization, Coursera, DeepLearning.AI 2018 ▪ Image and video processing, Coursera, Duke University 2014 ▪ Heterogeneous Parallel Programming, Coursera, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign 2014 ▪ Programming Languages, University of Washington 2014
SKILLS	Machine Learning: PyTorch, JAX Programming: Python, C#, Java, C/C++, Swift, Objective-C, Scheme, Racket, ML, CUDA

Other Technologies: Docker and Kubernetes, NodeJS, MongoDB, Neo4j, Wolfram Mathematica
Game Engines: Unity, Unreal Engine

HOBBIES Photogrammetry, Digital Photography, Hiking

- REFERENCES**
- **Dr. Anh Totti Nguyen**
Associate Professor, Auburn University
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 - **Dr. Trung Bui**
Senior Research Scientist & Research Manager, Adobe Research
bui@adobe.com
 - **Dr. Cor-Paul Bezemer**
Associate Professor, University of Alberta
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